

Smoothen an image: If your image contains dots (typical of a photo taken in low light), you can try the *Filters > Enhance > Despeckle* filter. Set the values so you get the best results. If Despeckle does not smoothen the image, you can try the Blur filter.

There are several options in Blur, such as motion blur, which can cause the effect of the pic having been taken while moving.

Sharpen an image: This filter makes the edges of objects stand out more clearly, but at the same time, it can also cause unwanted noise. Find it in *Filters > Enhance > Sharpen*.

Light effects: Want to add a sun? Or a star? Or create a glare effect? This is great for party shots. Try the Light Effects. There's lots to do by trial and error here.

There are many more filters, of course, and if you want even more options, there are always plug-ins you can get.

The GIMP can be downloaded from www.gimp.org, where you will also find documentation and resources. The latest release is version 2.21.

5.4 Inkscape

We raved about what The GIMP is and what it can do. But there is something else in open source that can help advanced graphics designers manipulate 3D vector graphics. Inkscape works on the W3C (World Wide Web Consortium) standard Scalable Vector Graphics (SVG).

SVG is a language to describe graphics in XML, which will also make the graphics Web- compliant. Inkscape is a relatively new application that sprang up in 2003 from the *Sodipodi* graphics editor, a free graphics editor released under the GNU GPL.